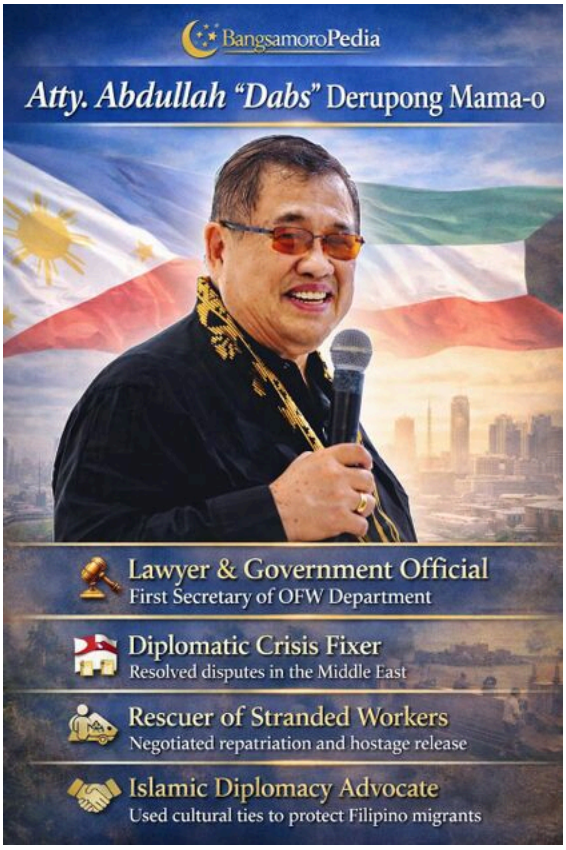
Abdullah D. Mama-o

Atty. Abdullah "Dabs" Derupong Mama-o is a Filipino lawyer, diplomat, and government official who served as the inaugural Secretary of the Department of Migrant Workers (DMW) under President Rodrigo Roa Duterte.

A Maranao leader with deep engagement in Middle Eastern diplomacy, he became known for applying what has been described as the **"Islamic Factor of Diplomacy"**, a practical approach that draws on shared religious and cultural identity to resolve labor crises and secure the welfare of Overseas Filipino Workers (OFWs). :contentReference[oaicite:0]{index=0}

His public service is marked by high-stakes negotiations, crisis response, and institution-building, particularly in situations involving distressed Filipino workers abroad.



Atty. Abdullah "Dabs" Derupong Mama-o

Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Maranao
Religion	Islam
Profession	Lawyer, Diplomat, Government Official
Education	San Beda College of Law
Notable Position	Secretary, Department of Migrant Workers
Years Active	2016–2022 (government service)

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Early Life and Background

Abdullah Derupong Mama-o is of Maranao descent, one of the major Muslim ethnolinguistic groups in the Philippines.

His background within a Muslim Filipino community shaped his familiarity with Islamic culture and social structures, which later informed his diplomatic engagements in the Middle East.

Education

Mama-o pursued his legal education at San Beda College of Law in Manila, where he graduated as part of the Class of 1972. :contentReference[oaicite:1]{index=1}

He was a classmate of Rodrigo Duterte, a connection that would later intersect with his role in government service during Duterte's presidency.

Government Career

Presidential Adviser on OFW and Muslim Concerns (2016–2022)

Following the assumption of President Duterte in 2016, Mama-o was appointed as **Presidential Adviser on Overseas Filipino Workers and Muslim Concerns**. :contentReference[oaicite:2]{index=2}

In this role, he functioned as a senior adviser and field negotiator, frequently deployed to the Middle East to address urgent labor and diplomatic concerns involving Filipino workers.

His work included direct engagement with foreign officials, employers, and diplomatic counterparts to resolve disputes, facilitate repatriation, and improve labor conditions.

Special Envoy to Kuwait (2018)

In 2018, Mama-o was designated as **Special Envoy to Kuwait** during a diplomatic crisis between the Philippines and Kuwait. :contentReference[oaicite:3]{index=3}

The crisis emerged following the death of an Overseas Filipino Worker and subsequent tensions involving embassy rescue operations.

Mama-o played a key role in de-escalating the situation through diplomatic negotiations, contributing to the eventual easing of tensions and the lifting of the deployment ban after securing improved protections for Filipino workers.

Secretary of the Department of Migrant Workers (2022)

On March 9, 2022, Mama-o was appointed as the first Secretary of the Department of Migrant Workers in an **ad interim** capacity. :contentReference[oaicite:4]{index=4}

He oversaw the initial organization and transition of the department, which consolidated multiple government agencies into a unified institution dedicated to protecting the rights and welfare of OFWs.

This role placed him at the center of institutional reform aimed at streamlining services for millions of Filipinos working abroad.

Major Achievements and Institutional Contributions

Mama-o's government service involved several high-impact interventions, including:

- Leading negotiations in Saudi Arabia for the repatriation of approximately 11,000 stranded Filipino workers affected by a construction sector crisis
- Participating in diplomatic efforts in Libya that secured the release of abducted Filipino workers
- Overseeing the foundational establishment of the Department of Migrant Workers as a centralized government agency

These efforts highlight his role in crisis response, labor diplomacy, and institutional development.

Diplomatic Approach and Cultural Significance

A defining aspect of Mama-o's work is his use of the **"Islamic Factor of Diplomacy"**, a method grounded in shared religious and cultural understanding. :contentReference[oaicite:5]{index=5}

This approach enabled him to establish rapport with leaders and officials in Muslim-majority countries, creating communication channels that complemented formal diplomatic protocols.

His work has been recognized by the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos for addressing both the specific concerns of Muslim Filipino workers and the broader needs of the OFW community.

Chronology of Service

Period	Position
2016–2022	Presidential Adviser on OFW and Muslim Concerns
2018	Special Envoy to Kuwait
2022 (March–June)	Secretary, Department of Migrant Workers

Legacy

Atty. Abdullah D. Mama-o's career reflects a model of diplomacy that integrates cultural identity with practical negotiation.

His contributions lie in both crisis resolution and institutional development, particularly in advancing government mechanisms for the protection of Filipino workers abroad.

His role in establishing the Department of Migrant Workers marks a significant development in Philippine labor governance, with long-term implications for OFW welfare and state accountability.

Challenges

Much of Mama-o's work took place in complex and high-pressure environments involving international labor disputes, diplomatic tensions, and humanitarian concerns.

Navigating these situations required balancing national policy, foreign relations, and the immediate needs of distressed workers, often under urgent and sensitive conditions.

See Also

- Department of Migrant Workers
- Overseas Filipino Workers
- Philippine foreign service
- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos
- Philippines–Kuwait relations

- Profile suggested by Khalid Disomangcop (https://www.facebook.com/khalid.disomangcop.9)

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